

The Union IT Minister has also added that the country's digital economy is set to grow from \$400 billion to \$1 trillion in a mere five to seven years. It's a grandiose target, and we will have to wait and watch, but we all know that our IT infrastructure needs to improve drastically to achieve it.

AADHAR

As of June 2017, over 1.1 billion people have a number attached to their identity. Aadhar, the Hindi word meaning "foundation" is going on to become the basis of every aspect of our lives, but is also one of the most contested of government policies, especially because it seemingly infringes on an individuals' privacy. While the idea of Aadhar to establish accountability, exclude middlemen and curb corruption may seem perfectly justified, it cannot work without a secure cyberspace. Just recently a security lapse in about 210 state and government websites meant that the Aadhar details of beneficiaries registered with them was accessible publicly. While the government claimed that there was no leak from The Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI), such breaches shake the common man's trust in Aadhar.

Many argue that Aadhar should be made mandatory, and eventually become the only identity proof of an individual in India, whilst others have gone to court, and the Supreme Court is currently considering whether the right to privacy is fundamental or not.

"The availability of large datasets of Aadhaar numbers along with bank account numbers and phone numbers on the Internet increases the risk of financial fraud," a report by Centre for Internet and Society said.

The Supreme Court, in March this year had ruled that Aadhar cannot be made compulsory for welfare schemes like Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme and Employees Pension Scheme.

"I feel concerns regarding privacy surrounding Aadhar are quite valid. Though data security for Aadhar has not been breached so far, it is a very real issue of concern as not only can data be misused by those seeking to

monetise personal information about Aadhar users, but there is even the threat of identity theft," says Narayan, who has done extensive research on digital initiatives of the government.

Despite the apparent doom and gloom being portrayed, a digital identity for citizens is a must as the world itself moves almost entirely digital over the next few decades, and it's no mean feat for a country like India to be leading the world in this effort.

SMART CITIES

Launched in June 2015, the Smart Cities Mission looked to transform the country, especially rural areas, with a major thrust to technology and cloud services. The project entails not only economic development in the country

So far, 90 cities have been listed out for redevelopment, with a budget of ₹1,900 billion for the mission and it continues to grow. The project is attracting investments from both private and public sectors, including investors from abroad. But some of the basic features of smart cities including proper sanitation, standard housing, green cover, IT connectivity, solid waste management, etc., are only few parameters that must be met to call a city 'smart'. While the dream of achieving these technologically-advanced living blocks may seem a little distant, experts believe that cities must be made liveable first, which would mean citizens are empowered to spearhead the changes in urban planning.



Redeveloping rural sector through technology

but also enough job opportunities in the manufacturing and service sectors. The plan to build 100 new smart cities by 2022, entails schemes which will focus on slum rehabilitation, and improving urban services like water supply, waste management, urban mobility, among others. This especially gains importance when you consider that 70 per cent of India's population is expected to live in cities by 2030.

"There is no 'one shoe fits all' kind of a solution. Smart is not only better technology as perceived today. To be truly successful, smart cities must be design driven through active community participation that takes into consideration cultural diversity as well," Nidhi Gupta, Project Manager at Environmental Design Solutions Global told India Infoline.

DIGITAL PAYMENTS

In a world where digital is the general trend of living, digitisation as a route to development doesn't seem too implausible. But in India, where the general attitude is to hoard cash or gold at home, digital payments and digital cash seem a tough act to master. In fact, demonetisation, one of the biggest financial exercises undertaken in the history of our country (or the world?), managed to change people's attitudes about cash, at least for a while.

While digital transactions grew by about 55 per cent in 2016-17, the share of digital payments fell by about 3 percent in June as compared to the previous month.

"The slight fall should be a momentary blip as the leading drivers of digital payments are bound to go up through initiatives like automated